

POSITIVE DISCIPLINE SCRIPTS & PHRASES

50 Things to Say Instead of Yelling

(Situation-Specific Scripts for Ages 2-12)

By Daniel Tesfamariam

THE FORMULA: ACKNOWLEDGE + VALIDATE + REDIRECT

Step 1: ACKNOWLEDGE what they're doing/feeling

Step 2: VALIDATE their emotion (even if behavior isn't okay)

Step 3: REDIRECT to what they CAN do

Example: 'I see you're throwing blocks (acknowledge). You're frustrated (validate). You can throw soft balls outside instead (redirect).'

NOT LISTENING / IGNORING

Instead of: 'How many times do I have to tell you?!'

Try: 'I need your eyes on me. I have something important to say.'

Instead of: 'You never listen!'

Try: 'I notice you're focused on something else. I'll wait until you're ready.'

Instead of: 'DO IT NOW!'

Try: 'This needs to happen before [next fun thing]. Would you like to do it now or in 2 minutes?'

Instead of: 'Are you deaf?!'

Try: 'Let me come to you. [Touch shoulder, get on their level] Hey, I need your help with something.'

Instead of: 'If I have to say this again...'

Try: 'I've asked once. I'm going to help you do it now.'

HITTING / BITING / AGGRESSION

Instead of: 'Stop hitting RIGHT NOW!'

Try: 'I won't let you hurt. Bodies are not for hitting. I'm going to keep everyone safe.'

Instead of: 'We do NOT hit in this house!'

Try: 'You're so angry your body wants to hit. You CAN: stomp feet, squeeze a pillow, or punch this cushion.'

Instead of: 'Say you're sorry!'

Try: 'Let's check on your brother. How can we help him feel better?'

Instead of: 'What is WRONG with you?'

Try: 'Something big is happening inside you. Let's figure out what you need.'

Instead of: 'Go to your room!'

Try: 'Let's move to a calm space together until your body feels safe again.'

BEDTIME BATTLES

Instead of: 'Get in bed NOW!'

Try: 'It's time for our bedtime routine. Would you like to start with books or pajamas?'

Instead of: 'I don't care if you're not tired!'

Try: 'Your body needs rest to grow. You don't have to sleep yet - just rest quietly.'

Instead of: 'This is the LAST time I'm coming in!'

Try: 'I'll check on you one more time in 5 minutes. You're safe.'

Instead of: 'If you don't stay in bed...'

Try: 'Your bed is your cozy spot. If you need me, I'm right here.'

Instead of: 'ENOUGH stalling!'

Try: 'I know you want more time with me. Let's have our special bedtime chat and then lights out.'

SIBLING FIGHTING

Instead of: 'STOP FIGHTING!'

Try: 'I see two people who need help solving a problem. What happened?'

Instead of: 'Who started it?'

Try: 'It doesn't matter who started it. How can we fix it?'

Instead of: 'Share or I'll take it away!'

Try: 'You're both using this. How should we solve it? Timer? Trade?'

Instead of: 'Be nice to your sister!'

Try: 'I hear unkind words. In this family, we speak with respect. Try again.'

Instead of: 'That's IT, both of you go to your rooms!'

Try: 'You both need a break. Take 5 minutes apart, then let's solve this together.'

HOMEWORK / SCHOOL REFUSAL

Instead of: 'Just DO your homework!'

Try: 'Homework feels hard today. What part feels most overwhelming? Let's start with just ONE problem.'

Instead of: 'You're being lazy!'

Try: 'I can see you're stuck. Would you like help getting started, or do you need a 10-minute break first?'

Instead of: 'You're going to fail!'

Try: 'Struggling means you're learning something new. I believe you can figure this out.'

Instead of: 'No TV until homework is done!'

Try: 'Homework first, then fun stuff! How about we set a timer for 20 minutes of focused work?'

Instead of: 'You HAVE to go to school!'

Try: 'I hear you don't want to go. What's making school hard right now? Let's problem-solve together.'

REPAIR SCRIPTS (When YOU Lose Your Cool)

You WILL yell sometimes. You're human. Here's how to repair:

- * 'I yelled and I'm sorry. That wasn't okay. You didn't deserve that.'
- * 'I got really frustrated and I handled it badly. I'm working on doing better.'
- * 'Even grownups have big feelings sometimes. I should have taken a deep breath.'
- * 'I love you. My anger was about MY problem, not about you being bad.'
- * 'Can we have a redo? Let me try that conversation again the right way.'

Repair teaches your child: mistakes happen, relationships matter more than perfection, and it's brave to apologize.

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Calm parents raise calm kids. You've got this.